Shizza Fatima Shafqat
W101-08

The melodious echoes of Ranjha's flute and the whispers of Heer's exquisite beauty still linger in the air of Punjab. The tale of "Heer Ranjha" as narrated by author Waris Shah, begins with Ranjha, the youngest of eight, leaving his home in Takht Hazara due to an inheritance dispute. Ranjha, known for his admirable character and good looks, with his flute, arrives in Jhang--the village of the beautiful and brave Heer. Heer finds him sleeping on her boat and instantly falls in love with him. Due to societal and familial opposition, Heer is forced to marry another man but her bond with Ranjha remains strong. They continue to meet in secret until Heer's parents finally agree to their marriage. Unfortunately, their joy is short-lived. When Ranjha leaves Jhang to prepare for their eventual union, Heer is tragically poisoned by her own family. Ranjha, returning to unite with Heer, discovers the news of her death and dies at her grave in shock. This is the story that still resonates in the subcontinent to portray ever-lasting love.

The 'Heer Ranjha' tale has an enduring legacy that has been conveyed across generations in various forms including poetry, films, books, and oral storytelling. This research paper will delve into how this story varies through time and narrators. This paper employs a comparative approach, focusing on identifying elements in each version of the story across various mediums and narrators. This method will be instrumental in answering the research question: How do different narrator's objectives influence variation in this story and what is their objective? How do they convey it? How do these variations impact people from a social and religious point of view? This exploration will not only enhance our understanding of "Heer Ranjha" but also teach us about the cultural, historical, and spiritual significance of this story and the art of storytelling in the Punjab and, by extension, the Indian subcontinent.

Shizza Fatima Shafqat
W101-08

We will study the versions told by various storytellers: from the 18th-century Sufi poet Waris Shah to the contemporary Pakistani musician Ali Zafar; from the 17th-century Hindu poet Damodar Gulati to the celebrated Punjabi poet Bulleh Shah. Additionally, an oral narration of the story as heard by my mother from her grandmother will be studied. Dialogue with scholarly articles will also be integrated to enhance the analysis. A special focus will be placed on the climaxes, locations, and the overall structure of the story across all versions.

Waris Shah, also known as the “Shakespeare of Punjab", has narrated this story purely through the lens of a true sufi mystic[1]. He has told this story with beautiful metaphors and literary devices while presenting the story not just as a romantic narrative but also as an allegory for the soul's spiritual journey. Waris Shah writes this dialogue as the Pirs talk to Heer and Ranjha: “Children, we salute you. Remember God. Do not tarnish the world of love. Ranjha, you are Heer’s and Heer is yours. A pearl and ruby have come together.”(14) Extensive and detailed, his version spans over 12 years, incorporating dialogues and interactions that bring depth to each character. Unique to Waris Shah's narrative is the introduction of the "Pir " (Usborne, note 2) – spiritual guides who appear at moments of despair, offering motivation and wisdom to Heer and Ranjha whenever they are called upon.[2] The Pirs were: Khwaja Khizr, Baba Fariduddin Masud Ganjshakar (Shakarganj), Shahbaz Qalandar, Zakana, and Sayyid Jalal of Bukhara. These

---

[1] Waris Shah is famed for his impactful style and portrayal of Punjabi culture. His version of 'Heer Ranjha' is the most read version today due to its rich poetry and true-to-life depiction of his era's society. This blend of romantic narrative and cultural insight solidifies his work as a key piece in South Asian literature.

[2] ‘Pir’ is a person who is regarded as a spiritual leader. The disciples and followers of Pir are known as Murids’. Literally the word ‘Pir’ means an old man.

Pirs remain famous in Pakistan today primarily as symbols of Sufi wisdom and spirituality, deeply influencing cultural practices, arts, and fostering a sense of unity and peace across diverse communities. Their teachings and stories continue to be celebrated in literature, music, and at Sufi shrines, forming an integral part of Pakistan's rich spiritual heritage. Heer and Ranjha also have a shrine in Jhang which is visited by individuals to offer prayers in the hopes of fulfilling their romantic desires and aspirations.

Waris Shah's narrative also incorporates references to other tragic-romantic regional folk tales, which, like 'Heer Ranjha', are widely celebrated across the subcontinent. Examples of the tragic endings of Sohni Mahiwal, Mirza Sahiban, Sassi Punnun, and Laila Majnoun were often mentioned in the story. Waris Shah writes as Heer talks to Ranjha:

> "Hir replied, 'Do not upbraid women. None can be so persistent or steadfast as a woman. For the love of Joseph Zulaikha renounced her kingdom. For the love of Mahiwal Sohni was drowned in the river, Is not the love of Laila known throughout the world and does not the grass grow green on her tomb to this day? Sassi died a martyr in the burning sands and Shirin died too for the sake of her lover Farhad."(11)

The engaging dialogues, poetic expressions, and references to the Quran and other folktales in Waris Shah's work captivated readers, contributing to the widespread popularity of the book.

Damodar's version of "Heer Ranjha," told from Heer's perspective, skillfully blends themes of devotion, empathy, and spiritual enlightenment, often employed by Sufi

poets and Hindu mystics in Punjab as metaphors for spirituality.[3] (The Analysis of Heer Damodar) Heer is characterized as strong-willed and fearless, yet Ranjha's flute softens her, illustrating a transformation from pride to humility. Damodar poetically expresses Heer's deep longing and pain in separation from Ranjha, elevating their love to a spiritual plane where she reveres Ranjha as "Kamil Murshid," which is a Sufi term for a spiritual guide. This mirrors the devotion in Sufi traditions towards Pirs and the Divine, emphasizing the belief that struggle and suffering are essential for spiritual growth and transformation. Additionally, Damodar incorporates Pirs into the narrative, appearing in Heer's dreams, where they encourage and protect her, symbolizing divine support in her pursuit of love and personal truth.

Bulleh Shah's famous poem Ranjha Ranjha Kardi illustrates the Sufi concept where the love transcends your "self".The poem narrates how Heer, through continuously chanting Ranjha's name, feels that she transforms into Ranjha, illustrating the Sufi idea of self-transcendence through love. The first verse of the poem translates to:

رانجھا رانجھا کردی نی،

میں آپے رانجھا ہو،

Repeating the name of Ranjha,

I have become Ranjha myself (Bulleh Shah)

This transformation is so deep that Heer's own identity seems to dissolve, and she desires to be recognized not as herself, but as Ranjha, reflecting her complete absorption in her love. The concluding part of the poem introduces the notion of divine orchestration,

[3] Sufism is traditionally associated with Islam rather than Hinduism. However, it's important to note that in regions like South Asia, where both Hinduism and Islam have coexisted for centuries, there have been instances of cultural, spiritual, and philosophical overlap. There are many traditions (for example rituals in weddings) that have been influenced by Hindu traditions and vice versa.

suggesting that the Heer and Ranjha's love story is intertwined with a greater, spiritual narrative of life.

The song “Dastan-e-ishq” by Ali Zafar incorporates the poetry of Bulleh Shah. The first verse of the song is the actual Bulleh Shah poem “Ranjha Ranjha Kardi” where Heer is telling the audience to call her Ranjha as she is one with him now. Ali Zafar has added the following lyrics: “I am ready to dance to persuade my beloved People do everything for love, let me persuade my beloved by dancing” (Zafar) These lyrics emphasizes the power Ranjha had on Heer and her actions stating how Heer is willing to defy her status and dance to win her beloved's heart -- a metaphor for the soul's journey and its trials in pursuit of divine love. This story is a look at the story of Heer Ranjha from a modern lens as the modern music and lyric translations catches the attention of a younger audience.

Waris Shah’s story is said to be conventional while Damodar’s story is considered unique (Soofi par. 3). Bulleh Shah's few lines of poetry sums up the love that Heer had for Ranjha, while Dastan-e-ishq tells the extended story of Bulleh Shah’s poem. All these stories have one common factor: they portray how the intensity of love between Heer and Ranjha is comparable to that of loving God . This is an important cornerstone of Sufism philosophy. Even though this tale is told for entertainment, the lesson it carries is about divine love. This Qissa unfolds the many layers of social norms and family structures of Punjab in the past. This tale also helps the audience learn about the traditions about the past. Waris Shah has mentioned other cities of Pakistan and used unique similes and metaphors for comparison which might be famous at the time but are not widely used

anymore. These tales are considered as folk treasures which scholars use to represent Pakistan to the new generation and to that world. (Quddus 192)

Waris Shah and Bulleh Shah are celebrated in Pakistan for their sufistic work as the tradition of sufism is very active in Pakistan (and the subcontinent). Sufism's role in the faith highlights the importance of "Heer Ranjha" in portraying devotion to God and His Prophets, resonating strongly with the community. The story of "Heer Ranjha" significantly impacts social perspectives by challenging traditional norms around love, marriage, and societal structures. It addresses gender roles, portraying Heer as a strong character who does not follow patriarchal expectations. The tale also resonates with themes of Sufism like promoting ideas of spiritual love and communal harmony, particularly in regions like Pakistan where Sufism is influential. Lastly, it serves as an educational tool, highlighting the richness of South Asian history and literature.

After this analysis we can see how Waris Shah, recognized for his Sufi inclinations, uniquely incorporated Sufi terminology and the names of Pirs in his work, highlighting their significance and distinguishing his version from others. His version has metaphors relating to the Quran and love symbolizing love of God. Waris Shah in his epilogue says as he compares his love: “Waris Shah is anxious to see God’s face even as Hir longed for her lover” (epilogue). Damodar, while telling this story through a beautiful poetic prose, has also mentioned Pirs and the intensity of love shown by the lovers. The limited information available about Damodar could be a reason why people might not have formed as strong a personal connection with his version of the story. Even though Damodar’s version is known to be the first version to exist, his story is based

more on realistic social issues instead of weaving the story with Sufi motifs. Mushtaq Soofi says in his Dawn article about Damodar's work:

> "Poets like Muqbal, Waris Shah and Charag Awan to name just a few built their versions based on Damodar's narrative, albeit with some changes here and there to suit their creative needs in different historical conditions. Damodar constructed the structure of the story encompassing the life of an individual in all its social and existential dimensions. The main protagonists he created emerged as eternal symbols of defiance of class and tribal norms that forcibly offered individuals at the altar of traditions born of needs that were considered to be essential to sustain the hierarchical socio-political structure." (Soofi par. 4)

Bulleh Shah, renowned for his contributions to Sufism, captured the essence and intensity of love and story in just a few lines of his poetry. Bulleh Shah's legacy includes a shrine where people come to offer prayers and some of the most celebrated poems in Pakistani literature. Bulleh Shah's concise yet powerful version of the story was so impactful that contemporary artists like Ali Zafar have integrated it into their work. His poem captures the story's essence without explicitly narrating it, assuming familiarity from the reader. Bulleh Shah has also written "Piya Ghar Aya" which has been composed and performed by many Qawals (performers of Qawali) such as Abu Muhammad and Fareed Ayaz on Coke Studio (Muhammad and Ayaz). This Qawali spreads the messages of Sufism through the mention of the Qissa of Laila Majnoo and Heer Ranjha. Hence, the theme of tales and Sufism were common in the works of Bulleh Shah.

Musician Ali Zafar has, while targeting the 21st century audience, retold this tale through modern music. Even though he is not predominantly known for Sufi music, he

incorporated “Ranjha Ranjha Kardi” by Bulleh Shah in his song to spread the Sufi message. A line from his song, "Becoming a wanderer (nomad) doesn't bring insult to me, I am ready to dance to persuade my beloved," exemplifies the inherent message of devotion. Ali Zafar's fame as a celebrated singer has helped introduce this version to younger generations, despite not being widely recognized for Sufi song renditions.

All these versions of Heer Ranjha serve a particular function: spreading and representing the message of Sufism and the love one should have from God. From a Sufi lens, this story is far more than just a tale for entertainment. Sufism is a mystical Islamic tradition that emphasizes the inner, spiritual journey toward a direct, personal experience of the Divine through love, devotion, and self-transcendence. Sufi mystics interpret this story as an allegory for the soul’s longing and journey towards divine love and truth. This can help the scholarship to understand the impact stories have on a community's psychology, and also learn more in the field of Cultural and Religious Studies. This story also exists outside the Sufi tradition including stories told at home by elders and how it is portrayed in music and movies.

In the everyday home setting, I draw on my mother’s version of the story. She first heard this tale at the age of ten, narrated by her grandmother who lived during the pre-partition era of Pakistan and India. My mother's residence in Sahiwal, situated relatively close to Sargodha in Punjab—the region from which Ranjha hailed—lends an authentic regional dimension to her narration. This version with its familial perspective also exemplifies the significant role of oral storytelling in maintaining and perpetuating this narrative through generations and across communities. My mother mentioned how filmmakers have adapted this story into movies, including the melodies played by Ranjha

on his flute. Mystic Sufis used to come to her neighborhood and spread the message of love and peace quoting Heer Ranjha. In the version narrated by my mother, the story begins with Ranjha, the youngest of four brothers, leaving his home due to the taunts of his brothers' wives. He sets out to find and marry Heer, journeying from Sargodha to Jhang, where he encounters the Sial tribe. Disguising his identity, Ranjha takes up work on Heer's farm. Heer, drawn to the forest by the sound of Ranjha's flute, often dances to his music. Heer does not know that the musician is Ranjha. They gradually fall in love. Heer's uncle, suspicious of Ranjha's true intentions, convinces her father to arrange her marriage to another man. This makes them sad and they plan to elope. As they make their way to the forest, they are tragically shot by their families. This story acts more like a warning or lesson for young kids to not defy their elder's traditions.

My mother's version has been filtered and refined to form an appropriate story for young children. It does not portray intense love or detailed dialogues. The activities, including meeting in secret and disrespecting parents are filtered out. This version has many differences from the common plotline as the versions mentioned above. In this story, the brothers are shown to be affectionate towards Ranjha, but the wives are shown to hate him, reflecting common themes in contemporary family dramas. Only in this version, Heer has been shown as a person who loves to dance unlike the rest where she is shown to be brave and strong. There is no mention of "poison" in this version giving this story a relativistic effect. Other authors, to portray a more heartbreaking and emotional ending, have incorporated the ending of a more long-lasting pain and sorrow. Killing people in the name of honor was a common practice in the past. The locations remain the same while there was no "helper" for Heer in this story. This version is simplified, likely

to discourage children from emulating certain actions. It teaches lessons such as sibling love, elder respect, honesty, and obedience to parents.

In conclusion, the tale of 'Heer Ranjha,' as explored through various narrators and mediums, highlights its enduring appeal and adaptability. This research illustrates how each rendition not only reflects the unique vision of its teller but also the socio-cultural and spiritual context of their era. The generational version of Heer Ranjha has been varied to convey lessons, Sufi mystics have shaped the story to spread the message of Sufism, and modern musicians and movie directors have changed the story more dramatically for entertainment purposes and to make it more appealing to the modern audience. Whether it is through the poetic depth of Waris Shah, the empathetic portrayal by Damodar, the soulful renditions of Bulleh Shah, or the contemporary musical interpretations by artists like Ali Zafar, "Heer Ranjha" remains impactful, surpassing both time and cultural limits in its appeal to audiences.

Shizza Fatima Shafqat
W101-08

Bibliography:

Muhammad, Abu, and Fareed Ayaz. "Piya Ghar Aya." Coke Studio, Season 11, Episode 3, Coke Studio Pakistan, 2018, youtu.be/WzlO79d3S8c

Shah, Waris. The Adventures of Hir and Ranjha. Translated by Charles Frederick Usborne, edited with an introduction and notes by Mumtaz Hasan, P.Owen, 1973.

Quddus, Syed Abdul. "Tales of Beauty and Love." Punjab, the Land of Beauty, Love, and Mysticism, Part One, Royal Book Co., 1992, p. 181-205.

Bulleh Shah. "Ranjha Ranjha Kardi." Translated by Ahkram, All Poetry, allpoetry.com/Ranjha-Ranjha-Kardi. Accessed 13 Nov. 2023.

Zafar, Ali. "Dastan-E-Ishq." Jhoom, Silent Roar Productions, 2011

Shafqat, Rukhsana. Oral narration of "Heer Ranjha." Personal interview. 30 November 2023

“The Analysis of Heer Damodar.” Living Sufism, 17 May 2021, livingsufism.org/the-analysis-of-heer-damodar/.

Soofi, Mushtaq. "Damodar Gulati: Poet Who Immortalised Heer and Ranjha - Part I."DAWN.COM, Dawn Newspaper, 7 June 2013.